

1.2 Anti-spyware

Judging from its name, you'd assume spyware was simply malware that monitors your PC activities. Spyware indeed collects personal information regarding what sites you visit and for how long. However, it can also wrest control from the user. It redirects one's browser activity and even permits the installation of additional software without one's consent or knowledge. Spyware doesn't infect neighbouring computers; it attacks by exploiting software loopholes. Some of its other more damaging effects include:

- Higher CPU utilisation
- Unwanted disk usage
- System crashes
- Software freezing
- Start-up failures
- Lower connection speeds

Spyware has several routes of infection. A common method is by "piggy-backing" on software downloads (such as Kazaa and Limewire). It can also come bundled with shareware. Keep in mind that the download itself is still safe, once the software is installed the spyware will be as well. Spyware authors often repackage popular freeware with installers for spyware.

Browsers such as Internet Explorer prevent any downloads from taking place without the user's permission. Through security holes in the web browser, certain web pages can override this and install spyware on the user's PC. This has come to be known as "drive-by download" since the user is helpless during the attack. It should be noted that later versions of IE have amended these loopholes.

Certain freeware "anti-spyware" programs can also contain spyware. There are currently over 300 listed applications. Such programs are classified as "rogue" anti-spyware programs. Examples of such malicious programs are Spy Wiper, WorldAntiSpy, Spylocked and Antivirus Gold. Many web pages associated with Adware Report, e-Spyware, NonToxic-Internet and others also come under rogue/suspect anti-spyware sites.